Moscow had refused to allow him to leave the country, a fact later confirmed by Margot.

On 17 February, Honecker announced he did not want to undergo any more operations, despite his condition worsening – his kidneys had been stricken by cancer, but now other organs, such as his liver, had been affected. He did not want to go to a hospital in Moscow either, because, as Friedrich Wolff explained, ‘the conditions there would be too problematical for him’. Apart from the possibility of being arrested, Erich was afraid of being harassed by the press. Wolff again called upon Bonn to allow Honecker to join Sonja and Leo in Chile.

Meanwhile, over in Bonn, Wolfgang von Geldern, a CDU lawmaker, called for a block on a U$69.4 million loan chancellor Kohl promised to Chile ‘until the Honecker case is cleared up and Chile extradites him’.34 During May, Erich – along with Mielke, Stoph, Kessler and Albrecht – was accused, in a 783-page indictment, of taking part in the ‘collective manslaughter’ of sixty-eight people as they attempted to flee East Germany. A bulging folder containing the indictment was delivered by courier to the Chilean embassy on Yunosti Street. Soon after, a notable chill entered the air when Clodomiro Almeyda – the ambassador who had facilitated Honecker’s refuge – was replaced with James Holger. More than anything else, Holger remembered the confinement in which Honecker found himself was difficult, ‘because it was very humiliating for someone proud of his status as former head of state being cooped up in a golden cage’.35

Finally, as Chile’s position became untenable, Aylwin assured Chancellor Kohl in June that Honecker would leave the embassy. Behind the scenes, though, the action continued to be erratic, ‘like, two steps forward, one step back,’ according to Bonn’s Foreign Minister Klaus Kinkel. ‘We kept pressing.’

An important moment came during that stiflingly hot summer, when Holger made an appearance at the Chancellery in Bonn on 22 June 1992, to announce to Friedrich Bohl, a senior aide to Kohl, that Chile wanted to act. ‘He reported in absolute discretion on the recent change in the attitude of the Chilean government,’ Bohl stated.